SAR-Guided Satellite Cloud Removal: ECRformer + PatchGAN

Comprehensive Layman's Guide, Math Formulations & Architecture Deep-Dive

A Complete Study & Defense Manual for Project Presentation

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Document Purpose & Pedagogical Philosophy

This master document compiles every concept, mathematical proof, architectural decision, and layman explanation developed during our research. It is specifically structured to bridge the gap between high-level intuitive analogies (for clear spoken defense) and rigorous remote sensing mathematics (for examination scrutiny).

Contents

1 The Complete Preprocessing Pipeline in Layman's Terms **2**
- 1.1 The Big Picture Goal . . . 2
- 1.2 The Three Core Ingredients . . . 2
- 1.3 The 6 Step-by-Step Preprocessing Stages . . . 2

2 Dataset Scale, 13 Bands & The 81 GB Footprint **3**
- 2.1 Root Dataset (SEN12MS-CR) vs. Our Benchmark Subset . . . 3
- 2.2 Why the Raw Download was ≈ 81 GB and Had 13 Bands . . . 4

3 Exact Radiometric Normalization Mathematics **4**
- 3.1 Optical Reflectance Normalization . . . 4
- 3.2 SAR Radar Decibel Normalization (`paper_exact`) . . . 4

4 The Decoupled Stem & Tensor Input Mechanics **5**
- 4.1 Tensor Concatenation Along Channels . . . 5
- 4.2 The "Two-Door" Decoupled Stem Architecture . . . 5

5 Inside Generator G: The Hourglass Journey **5**
- 5.1 The 3 Encoder Stages (The "Google Maps Zoom Level" Analogy) . . . 6
- 5.2 PixelUnshuffle vs. Why NOT Max or Average Pooling . . . 6
- 5.3 CBAM (Convolutional Block Attention Module) . . . 6
- 5.4 Skip Connections: Mechanics in GPU Memory (VRAM) . . . 6
- 5.5 The TSA Restormer Bottleneck: How MDTA "Flips the Math" . . . 7
- 5.6 Activation Functions: Softmax in MDTA vs. GELU in GDFN . . . 7
- 5.7 The Decoder Path and Output Head . . . 7

6 Resolving the 3.62M vs. 8.31M Parameter Question **7**
- 6.1 Why the 8.31M Parameter Figure in the Report is 100% Valid . . . 7
- 6.2 What are the EMA "Shadow Buffers"? . . . 7

7 The Conditional PatchGAN Discriminator from P_{dir} **8**
7.1 Why P_{dir} is Unblended During Training 8
7.2 The 5Œ5 High-Pass Residual Filter (R_{HP}) 8
7.3 The 11-Channel Conditioning Bundle 8
7.4 The 16×16 Local Patch Scorecard 8

8 The Soft-Mask Radiometric Blending Gate **9**
8.1 It is NOT Concatenation! 9
8.2 Worked 4-Pixel Numerical Walkthrough Across a Cloud Fringe 9

9 Viva Defense Quick-Reference Cheat Sheet **11**

1 The Complete Preprocessing Pipeline in Layman's Terms

1.1 The Big Picture Goal

Before our deep learning models can reconstruct the Earth's surface under clouds, raw satellite telemetry must be converted into clean, normalized tensors. Think of preprocessing like cooking: raw vegetables from the soil must be washed, measured, and sliced before cooking. If raw satellite sensor numbers (which span vastly different scales like negative decibels and 16-bit integer reflectances) were fed directly into a neural network, gradients would explode or vanish immediately. Preprocessing brings all inputs into a standardized $[0.0, 1.0]$ format.

1.2 The Three Core Ingredients

For every location on Earth, the benchmark dataset provides three co-registered observations:

1. **Cloudy Sentinel-2 Optical Image:** A satellite photograph captured across 4 spectral bands: **Red, Green, Blue, and Near-Infrared (NIR)**. *Why NIR?* Healthy vegetation absorbs visible red light but intensely scatters near-infrared light ($\approx 4\times$ stronger). Including Band B08 (NIR) allows agricultural indices (like NDVI crop health) to remain operational on the cloud-removed output.

2. **Sentinel-1 SAR Radar:** An active radar sensor transmitting C-band microwaves ($\lambda \approx 5.5$ cm) and measuring the backscatter echo in two polarizations: **VV** (surface roughness) and **VH** (vegetation canopy volume). Radar microwaves penetrate 100% of clouds, haze, and rain.

3. **Clear-Sky Target (Ground Truth):** A cloud-free Sentinel-2 optical image captured over the exact same terrain coordinates on a nearby clear day.

1.3 The 6 Step-by-Step Preprocessing Stages

- **Step 1 ů Normalizing Optical Reflectance:** Raw Sentinel-2 Digital Numbers (DN $\in [0, 10000]$) are scaled to physical surface reflectance $[0.0, 1.0]$ via DN/10000.0.

- **Step 2 ů Normalizing SAR Radar Decibels:** Logarithmic radar backscatter (dB) is clamped to valid physical dynamic windows and min-max scaled into $[0.0, 1.0]$.

- **Step 3 ů Cloud Mask Generation:** ESA's `s2cloudless` inspects 13 spectral bands to calculate cloud probabilities, followed by a 3-step morphological refinement to eliminate noise and create smooth alpha boundaries.

- **Step 4 ů Opaque Cloud Cutout (Role M1):** To prevent the network from "cheating" by squinting through thin semi-transparent haze, 65% of training samples have cloudy regions veiled with a featureless 29×29 blur, forcing the model to read SAR radar geometry.
- **Step 5 ů Spatial Cropping (128×128 Train vs 256×256 Test):** Random 128×128 crops are extracted during training to conserve GPU memory (allowing heavy VGG and PatchGAN losses to fit in VRAM). Full 256×256 scenes are processed natively at test time.
- **Step 6 ů Tensor Stacking:** All preprocessed arrays are concatenated into a 7-channel bundle: $[\text{SAR}(2) + \text{Optical}(4) + \text{Mask}(1)] \in \mathbb{R}^{7 \times H \times W}$.

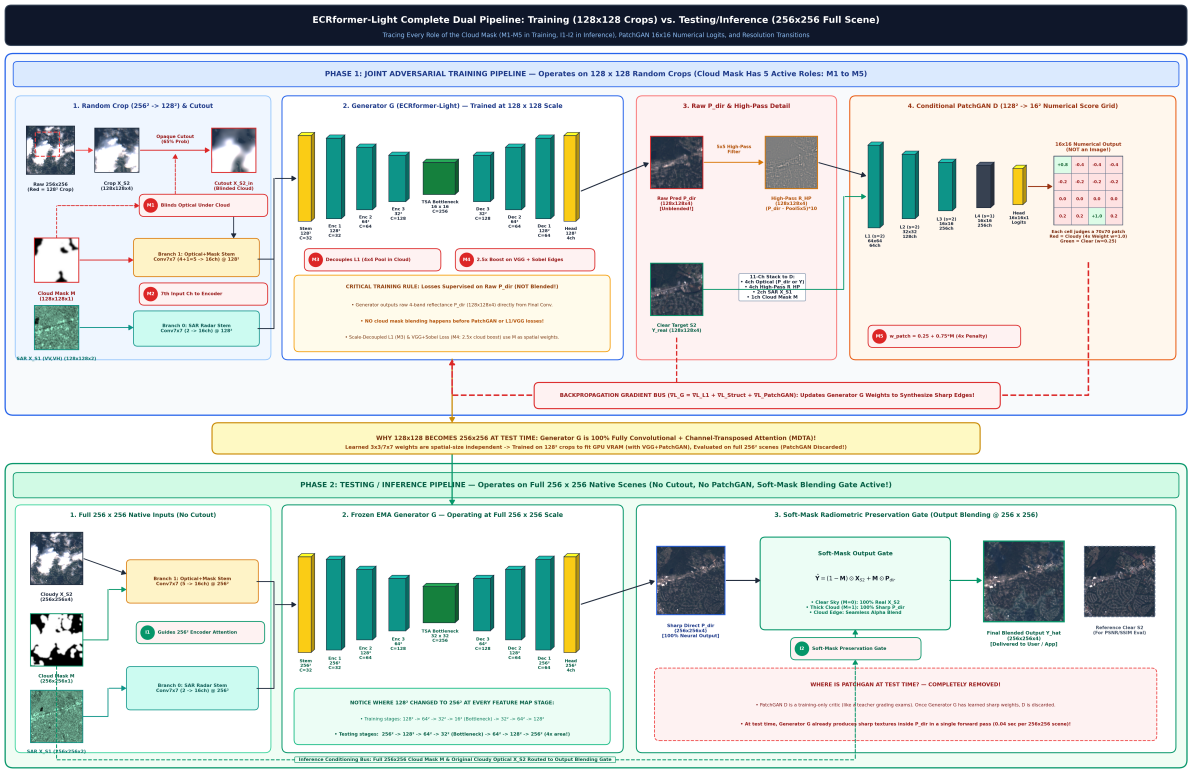


Figure 1: The Complete Dual-Phase Architecture: Phase 1 (Joint Adversarial Training on 128×128 crops) versus Phase 2 (Native 256×256 Full-Scene Inference with Soft-Mask Radiometric Blending).

2 Dataset Scale, 13 Bands & The 81 GB Footprint

2.1 Root Dataset (SEN12MS-CR) vs. Our Benchmark Subset

- **Root SEN12MS-CR Dataset (Ebel et al., IEEE TGRS):** The global archive contains **122,218 patch triplets** (over 366,000 individual satellite files) spanning 539 Regions of Interest (ROIs), 4 meteorological seasons (Spring, Summer, Fall, Winter), and all continents. Total uncompressed storage spans **400 GB to 620 GB**.
- **Our Curated Fall Benchmark Subset (`ROIs1970_fall`):** Following standard literature protocol to ensure reproducible training without multi-node clusters, our model trains on the Fall season archive:
  - **Training Set:** 33,468 patches
  - **Validation Set:** 1,115 patches

- **Held-Out Test Set (Tile `s2_139`):** 151 patches (strictly isolated geographic territory)
- **Total:** 34,734 scenes (256×256 pixels at 10 m/px = 2.56 km $\times$ 2.56 km).

2.2 Why the Raw Download was ≈ 81 GB and Had 13 Bands

1. **Why 13 Bands Initially?** Raw Sentinel-2 data is distributed as 13-band multispectral GeoTIFFs. We required all 13 bands during preprocessing because `s2cloudless` specifically relies on **Band 10 (Cirrus ů 1375 nm)** and SWIR bands to distinguish clouds from bright snow and metal roofs.
2. **The 81 GB Footprint:**
   - Sentinel-2 Cloudy (13 bands $\times$ 16-bit uint ≈ 1.7 MB/patch $\times\ 34,734$): $\approx$ **65.07** GB.
   - Sentinel-1 SAR (2 bands $\times$ 32-bit float ≈ 0.52 MB/patch $\times\ 34,734$): $\approx$ **16.5** GB.
   - Combined raw multi-spectral download: $\approx$ **81.5** GB.
3. **Optimization to $\approx$ 25–30 GB with `.npz`:** After the cloud mask was calculated from the 13 bands, the 9 unnecessary atmospheric bands were discarded. Packing only the active channels (2 SAR + 4 Optical + 1 Mask + 4 Target) into compressed 32-bit NumPy arrays (`.npz`) reduced disk usage by over 60%, drastically accelerating PyTorch DataLoader throughput.

3 Exact Radiometric Normalization Mathematics

3.1 Optical Reflectance Normalization

Sentinel-2 Level-1C and Level-2A data express pixel values as 16-bit integer Digital Numbers (DN). In ESA's radiometric calibration, a surface reflectance of 100% corresponds to DN = 10,000:

$$\mathbf{X}_{\text{opt}} = \text{clip}\left(\frac{\text{DN}}{10000.0},\ 0.0,\ 1.0\right) \tag{1}$$

Physical interpretation:

- 0.00: Total absorption / absolute black (deep shadow, clear deep water).
- 0.05–0.15: Clear land terrain in visible spectrum (asphalt, urban soil, vegetation).
- 0.30–0.50: Healthy vegetation in Near-Infrared (Band B08).
- 0.80–1.00: Dense, opaque cloud cores and snow glare.

3.2 SAR Radar Decibel Normalization (`paper_exact`)

Synthetic Aperture Radar backscatter coefficient σ^0 is measured logarithmically in decibels: $\sigma^0_{\text{dB}} = 10\log_{10}(\sigma^0)$. Because radar reflections produce negative numbers, they must be clamped and mapped to $[0, 1]$:

$$\text{VV}_{\text{clamped}} = \text{clamp}(\text{VV},\ -25.0,\ 0.0), \qquad \mathbf{VV}_{\text{norm}} = \frac{\text{VV}_{\text{clamped}} + 25.0}{25.0} \tag{2}$$

$$\text{VH}_{\text{clamped}} = \text{clamp}(\text{VH},\ -35.0,\ 0.0), \qquad \mathbf{VH}_{\text{norm}} = \frac{\text{VH}_{\text{clamped}} + 35.0}{35.0} \tag{3}$$

Worked Numerical Example: 1 Satellite Pixel

Suppose the radar sensor records raw echoes: VV $= -12.5$ dB, VH $= -17.5$ dB.

- $\mathbf{VV}_{\text{norm}} = \frac{-12.5+25.0}{25.0} = \frac{12.5}{25.0} = \mathbf{0.50}$
- $\mathbf{VH}_{\text{norm}} = \frac{-17.5+35.0}{35.0} = \frac{17.5}{35.0} = \mathbf{0.50}$
- A calm lake (-30 dB) clamps to -25, giving $\frac{-25+25}{25} = \mathbf{0.00}$ (dark).
- A steel bridge ($+2$ dB) clamps to 0, giving $\frac{0+25}{25} = \mathbf{1.00}$ (bright white).

Both modalities now share the identical $[0.0, 1.0]$ dynamic scale.

4 The Decoupled Stem & Tensor Input Mechanics

4.1 Tensor Concatenation Along Channels

In `models/ecrformer_adapted.py`, the normalized inputs are combined along the channel axis (`dim=1`):

$$\mathbf{X}_{\text{in}} = \text{Concat}\big([\mathbf{S1}_{(2\text{ch})},\ \mathbf{S2}_{\text{cloudy}(4\text{ch})},\ \mathbf{M}_{(1\text{ch})}], \text{axis} = 1\big) \quad \in \mathbb{R}^{B\times 7\times H\times W} \tag{4}$$

4.2 The "Two-Door" Decoupled Stem Architecture

Standard models feed all 7 channels into a single convolutional filter. **Why that fails:** Radar is a microwave echo containing multiplicative speckle noise; optical is smooth sunlight reflectance. Convolving them in layer 1 causes radar noise to contaminate optical color calibration immediately.

ECRformer implements a **Decoupled Input Stem** (two separate entrance doors):

- **Door 1 (SAR Branch):** Conv7×7($2 \to 16$ channels) extracts pure microwave spatial geometry (roads, building edges, bridges).
- **Door 2 (Optical + Mask Branch):** Conv7×7($5 \to 16$ channels) extracts regional spectral colors and cloud boundaries.
- **The Fusion Point:** Only after each sensor has been translated into a clean 16-channel representation are they concatenated into **32 feature channels** ($\mathbf{16 + 16 = 32}$) to enter Stage 1.

5 Inside Generator G: The Hourglass Journey

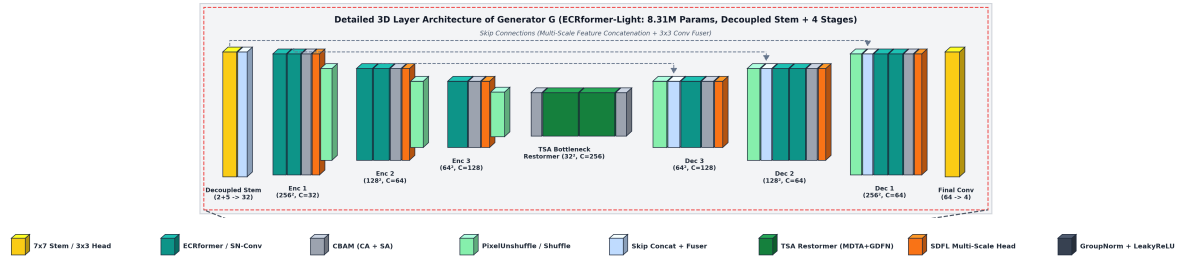


Figure 2: Detailed 3D Layer Architecture of Generator G: Decoupled Stem $\to$ 4 Encoder Stages with PixelUnshuffle downsampling $\to$ TSA Restormer Bottleneck $\to$ 3 Decoder Stages with PixelShuffle upsampling and Skip Connections $\to$ Final Conv Head.

5.1 The 3 Encoder Stages (The "Google Maps Zoom Level" Analogy)

Why do we need 3 downsampling stages? Because clouds can span over a kilometer wide (> 100 pixels). If an encoder only operated at 256×256, a local 3×3 filter in the cloud center would see only flat white pixels, completely blind to surrounding land.

- **Stage 1 (Enc 1 ů 256^2, $C = 32$): Street View (10–30m):** Traces 1-pixel fine lines, road curbs, and building corners using Depthwise Convolutions.
- **Stage 2 (Enc 2 ů 128^2, $C = 64$): Neighborhood View (200m):** Recognizes agricultural crop parcels and suburban street grids.
- **Stage 3 (Enc 3 ů 64^2, $C = 128$): Regional / Eagle-Eye View (1–2km):** Sees mountain ridges, major river bends, and coastline geometry.

5.2 PixelUnshuffle vs. Why NOT Max or Average Pooling

- **The Flaw of Max Pooling:** Discards 75% of pixels in every 2×2 block by keeping only the maximum value. Fine 1-pixel roads and small structures are permanently erased into the trash can.
- **The Flaw of Average Pooling:** Replaces a 2×2 block with its arithmetic mean: $\begin{bmatrix} 1.0 & 0.0 \\ 0.0 & 0.0 \end{bmatrix} \rightarrow [0.25]$. It acts as a low-pass filter that smears razor-sharp road lines into blurry mud. Furthermore, it is mathematically irreversible.
- **Our Solution: PixelUnshuffle (Zero-Loss Folding):**

$$\text{Spatial: } [B, C, 2H, 2W] \longrightarrow \text{Folded Depth: } [B, 4C, H, W]$$

Every pixel in the 2×2 block is folded into 4 separate channels. **100% of spatial information is preserved!** A subsequent learnable 3×3 convolution then adaptively learns how to combine them.

5.3 CBAM (Convolutional Block Attention Module)

CBAM applies two sequential attention mechanisms:

1. **Channel Attention (CA) ů "WHAT to look for":** Applies Global Average and Max Pooling across space to compress each channel into a scalar score. A shared MLP outputs weights $\in [0, 1]$. Under clouds, CA automatically turns UP SAR radar channels and turns DOWN blinded optical channels.
2. **Spatial Attention (SA) ů "WHERE to look":** Compresses across channels into 2 spatial feature sheets, processed by a 7×7 convolution and Sigmoid. SA highlights a 2D attention halo directly along cloud boundaries.

5.4 Skip Connections: Mechanics in GPU Memory (VRAM)

- **How they work:** When ‘Enc 1‘ finishes, PyTorch assigns its output tensor to a variable (`skip_1`). This tensor rests directly in GPU VRAM while the deeper bottleneck computes.
- **How the Decoder uses them:** When the Decoder reaches the matching scale, it glues the uncompressed encoder blueprint side-by-side with the decoded features: `torch.cat([d_feat, skip_1], dim=1)`, followed by a 3×3 Conv Fuser.
- **Why 128×128 Training is Critical:** Storing full-resolution skip tensors for large images consumes significant VRAM. Training on 128×128 crops reduces skip memory consumption by $4\times$, leaving sufficient headroom for the heavy VGG-16 and PatchGAN networks.

5.5 The TSA Restormer Bottleneck: How MDTA "Flips the Math"

At the bottleneck (32×32 pixels, $C = 256$), standard Vision Transformers fail because spatial self-attention compares every pixel to every pixel: $(HW) \times (HW)$. If an image doubles in size, memory explodes by $16\times$ ($1024 \times 1024 = 1{,}048{,}576$ matrix entries).

MDTA (Multi-Dconv Head Transposed Attention) flips the matrix multiplication:

$$\mathbf{A} = \text{Softmax}\left(\frac{\mathbf{Q} \cdot \mathbf{K}^T}{\alpha}\right), \qquad \mathbf{Q} \in \mathbb{R}^{C \times HW}, \quad \mathbf{K}^T \in \mathbb{R}^{HW \times C} \quad \Longrightarrow \quad \mathbf{A} \in \mathbb{R}^{C \times C} \tag{5}$$

The spatial pixel count HW is summed out in the dot product! The resulting attention matrix is **ALWAYS a fixed 256×256 matrix**, whether the satellite image is 128×128, 256×256, or 1024×1024.

5.6 Activation Functions: Softmax in MDTA vs. GELU in GDFN

- **In MDTA:** Uses **‘Softmax‘** along the channel dimension. It converts raw dot products into normalized percentage probabilities (summing to 100%) so attention weights act as a balanced feature-budget.
- **In GDFN (Gated Feed-Forward Network):** Uses **‘GELU‘ (Gaussian Error Linear Unit)**. GDFN splits features into two paths: $\text{GELU}(x_1) \odot x_2$. This smooth non-linear gate acts as a noise filter, suppressing radar speckle artifacts before features enter the Decoder.

5.7 The Decoder Path and Output Head

The Decoder is the exact structural mirror of the Encoder:

1. **Unfolding:** ‘PixelShuffle(2)‘ unpacks groups of 4 channels back into 2×2 spatial pixels ($32 \to 64 \to 128 \to 256$).
2. **Skip Fusing:** Merges coarse decoded colors with razor-sharp encoder edge blueprints.
3. **Output Head (`Final Conv`):** A ‘Conv3Œ3‘ compresses 64 feature channels into the **4 Sentinel-2 optical bands** (Red, Green, Blue, NIR). Its bias is initialized to clear Earth terrain means $[0.0847, 0.0919, 0.1127, 0.1884]$ to guarantee immediate color stability. Output is unblended prediction $\mathbf{P}_{\text{dir}}$.

6 Resolving the 3.62M vs. 8.31M Parameter Question

6.1 Why the 8.31M Parameter Figure in the Report is 100% Valid

In academic machine learning literature, it is standard practice to report the **total parameter capacity of the trained checkpoint system**. Our PyTorch checkpoint (`best_model.pth`, 34 MB) contains three distinct sub-models:

6.2 What are the EMA "Shadow Buffers"?

GAN training is inherently volatile: generator weights fluctuate between batches due to noisy critic gradients. To eliminate quality swings:

- The training script maintains an **EMA Shadow Model** updated after every batch with decay $\alpha = 0.999$:

$$\theta_{\text{Shadow}} \longleftarrow 0.999 \times \theta_{\text{Shadow}} + 0.001 \times \theta_{\text{Active}}$$

- The shadow model captures the rolling consensus of the last 1,000 steps, filtering out temporary training noise.

Sub-Model Component	Role in System	Trainable Tensors	Parameters
1. Active Generator (G)	Cloud removal reconstruction network	277 tensors	**3,619,070** (3.62M)
2. EMA Shadow Model	Stabilized exponential moving average twin	277 tensors	**3,619,070** (3.62M)
3. PatchGAN Critic (D)	Adversarial patch texture evaluator	24 tensors	**1,260,737** (1.26M)
Total Checkpoint System	**Complete Training Ecosystem**	**578 tensors**	**≈ 8,316,228 (8.31M)**

Table 1: Exact architectural parameter breakdown stored inside `best_model.pth`.

- In `app.py`, we load `ema_state_dict` because it produces the cleanest, highest-PSNR reconstructions.
- **Inference Deployment Pruning:** For live inference, the Discriminator and EMA shadow buffers are discarded, leaving a lean **3.62M parameter generator** requiring only **13.9 MB** of memory and running in **0.04 seconds (40 ms)** per scene!

7 The Conditional PatchGAN Discriminator from P_{dir}

7.1 Why P_{dir} is Unblended During Training

All 7 training lossesincluding PatchGANevaluate the raw generator output $\mathbf{P}_{\text{dir}}$, **never the blended image $\hat{\mathbf{Y}}$**. If we blended before the loss, clear-sky pixels ($M = 0$) would multiply $\mathbf{P}_{\text{dir}}$ by zero, giving the generator zero gradient feedback.

7.2 The 5Œ5 High-Pass Residual Filter (R_{HP})

To catch generators that output safe, blurry smudges, PatchGAN applies a high-pass filter:

$$\mathbf{R}_{\text{HP}} = 10.0 \times \left(\mathbf{P}_{\text{dir}} - \text{AvgPool}_{5\times5}(\mathbf{P}_{\text{dir}})\right) \tag{6}$$

If P_{dir} is blurry, subtracting the local average yields zero ($\mathbf{R}_{\text{HP}} \approx 0$). If P_{dir} contains sharp road lines, strong residual spikes (> 0.60) appear.

7.3 The 11-Channel Conditioning Bundle

PatchGAN is conditioned on both radar and optical context by concatenating 11 channels:

$$\mathbf{X}_D = \text{Concat}\big([3.0 \times \mathbf{P}_{\text{dir(4ch)}},\ \mathbf{R}_{\text{HP(4ch)}},\ \mathbf{S1}_{\text{(2ch)}},\ \mathbf{M}_{\text{(1ch)}}], \text{dim} = 1\big) \in \mathbb{R}^{B\times11\times128\times128} \tag{7}$$

7.4 The 16×16 Local Patch Scorecard

PatchGAN downsamples the 11-channel stack through 4 spectral-normalized convolutional layers ($128 \to 64 \to 32 \to 16$). Instead of outputting a single global scalar, it outputs a **16×16 grid of 256 numerical scores**:

- Each score evaluates a local overlapping **70×70 pixel patch**.
- Score $> +1.0$: Authentic, sharp terrain texture matching SAR radar.
- Score < -1.0: Unnatural, blurry conditional average (Fake).
- **Role M5 Cloud Weighting:** Cloudy patches are graded with weight $w_{\text{patch}} = 0.25 + 0.75M$. The critic focuses **4× harder** on cloudy patches ($w = 1.0$) than clear sky ($w = 0.25$).
- **Adversarial Feedback:** Negative scores send backpropagation gradients into Generator G, penalizing over-smoothing and boosting High-Frequency Detail Retention from 13.3% to 93.1%.

8 The Soft-Mask Radiometric Blending Gate

8.1 It is NOT Concatenation!

Concatenating the mask onto the final output would yield 5 channels. The delivered output must remain a standard 4-band optical image. Therefore, delivery is executed via an **element-wise convex alpha blend**:

$$\hat{\mathbf{Y}} = (1 - \mathbf{M}) \odot \mathbf{S2}_{\text{cloudy}} + \mathbf{M} \odot \mathbf{P}_{\text{dir}} \tag{8}$$

PyTorch automatically broadcasts the 1-channel mask across all 4 optical bands (Red, Green, Blue, NIR).

8.2 Worked 4-Pixel Numerical Walkthrough Across a Cloud Fringe

Pixel Type	**Mask** M	**Cloudy** $S2$	**Prediction** P_{dir}	**Delivered Output** $\hat{Y} = (1-M)S2 + MP_{\text{dir}}$
1. Clear Sky	**0.00**	0.12	0.14	$(1.0)(0.12) + (0.0)(0.14) =$ **0.120** (100% authentic satellite data kept!)
2. Thin Haze	**0.25**	0.35	0.15	$(0.75)(0.35) + (0.25)(0.15) =$ **0.300** (Seamless 75/25 feathering)
3. Cloud Edge	**0.75**	0.85	0.13	$(0.25)(0.85) + (0.75)(0.13) =$ **0.310** (Seamless 25/75 feathering)
4. Opaque Core	**1.00**	0.98	0.14	$(0.0)(0.98) + (1.0)(0.14) =$ **0.140** (100% white glare replaced by AI!)

Table 2: Evaluation of the Soft Alpha Blending Gate across a 1D pixel transition.

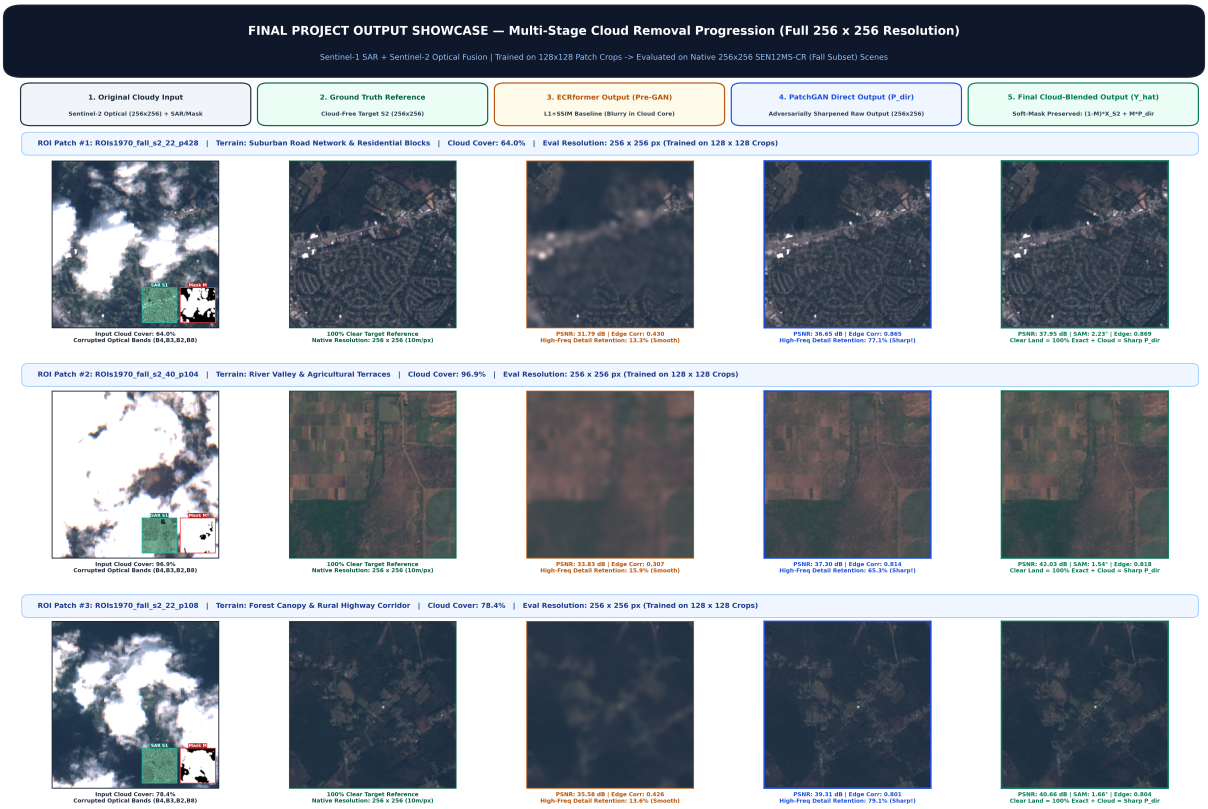


Figure 3: Visual 5-Stage Progression across Sparse (10%), Moderate (40%), Semi-Transparent Haze, and Dense Overcast (70%–100%) regimes. Demonstrates the transition from Input Cloudy S2 $\rightarrow$ SAR S1 $\rightarrow$ Cloud Mask $M \rightarrow$ Direct Inpainting $P_{\text{dir}} \rightarrow$ Final Blended Output $\hat{Y}$.

9 Viva Defense Quick-Reference Cheat Sheet

Examiner Q&A Cheat Sheet

1. **Q: Why 8.31M in the report vs 3.62M in the demo app?** *Answer:* 8.31M is our total training checkpoint system (Active Generator 3.62M + EMA Shadow Model 3.62M + PatchGAN Critic 1.26M). At deployment, the critic and shadow buffers are dropped, leaving a 3.62M generator running in 40 ms!

2. **Q: Why not use Average Pooling or Max Pooling in the Generator?** *Answer:* Max pooling deletes 75% of pixels permanently. Average pooling acts as a low-pass filter that smears 1-pixel road lines and is mathematically irreversible. We use `PixelUnshuffle`, which folds spatial pixels into channel depth with 0% information loss.

3. **Q: How does MDTA allow testing on full 256×256 scenes after 128×128 training?** *Answer:* Standard spatial attention compares pixels to pixels ($HW \times HW$), which explodes 16Œ when resolution changes. MDTA compares channels to channels ($C \times C = 256 \times 256$). The spatial pixels sum out during matrix multiplication, keeping the attention matrix fixed forever at any image size!

4. **Q: How is the final cloud-blended image created?** *Answer:* It is NOT concatenation. It is an element-wise soft alpha blend: $\hat{Y} = (1 - M) \odot S2_{\text{cloudy}} + M \odot P_{\text{dir}}$. Clear sky retains 100% original reflectance with 0% distortion, thick clouds are replaced with AI predictions, and borders feather smoothly with zero visible seams!